

1917

OFFENSIVE FAILS AT YPRES

On 31 July, Allied troops began an assault on the German front line around the Ypres salient, with the aim of breaking through to the Belgian ports to capture German U-boats. The offensive was a disaster. Shelling and rain turned the ground into a quagmire with water deep enough to drown a man. In November, Allied forces took Passchendaele, 7 km (5 miles) away, and the offensive was called off. Some 580,000 men died.

▷ Australian soldiers cross a devastated landscape at Ypres



“I died in hell, they called it Passchendaele.”

POET SIEGFRIED SASSOON, OCTOBER 1918

1915

1915 Six million Black Americans migrate north to work in war industries

1915 The International Women's Peace Conference takes place at The Hague, Netherlands

1915 Italy declares war on Austria-Hungary and enters World War I on the Allied side

1916 Irish republicans rise up against British rule; the rebellion is brutally suppressed



△ The Battle of Verdun

1916

FRENCH AND GERMAN TROOPS BATTLE FOR VERDUN

The longest battle of World War I began on 21 February when German forces bombarded the French fortress town of Verdun. The French were forced back but retaliated: under near constant bombardment and machine gun fire, the battle continued for ten months. In December, when the battle ended, the French held Verdun. More than 700,000 men died in the fighting.



◁ Maxim 303 MkII, WWI machine gun